Chapter Eleven

The First Plantagenet

In England, between 1147 and 1154, anarchy comes to an end

In England, civil war continued.

Eight years in, Stephen of Blois still held the crown. But Matilda, daughter of Henry I, camped in the English countryside and continued to press her claims. The king's armies controlled the southeast of England and the capital city of London; Matilda's soldiers dominated the southwest. Between them was a wasteland: "You could well go a whole day's journey and never find anyone occupying a village or land tilled," the *Anglo-Saxon Chronicle* explains.[1]

In 1147, Matilda's fourteen-year-old son Henry excused himself from his studies in Western Francia (his tutor was the well-regarded philosopher William of Conches, author of a masterwork intended to reconcile Greek natural philosophy with Christian orthodoxy) and headed to England. He had collected a small band of soldiers, probably by promising them a share of loot. As soon as he landed in England, rumors began to fly: Henry, it was said, had come with an entire army, or perhaps two, possibly with the king of France behind him, and was ready to devastate the opposition.

None of this was true. Henry's little group of adventurers lost several initial skirmishes against detachments of Stephen's soldiers and soon realized that there was no loot to be had. They deserted him, leaving the fourteen-year-old stranded in enemy territory. Henry sent a desperate message to his mother, but her treasury was exhausted. Finally, Stephen himself provided the money to get the child home.[2]